

## **PREMISES AND PROMISES OF SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING IN TOURISM**

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# **PREMISES AND PROMISES OF SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING IN TOURISM**

Ulrike Gretzel and Kyung-Hyan Yoo

## **INTRODUCTION**

The term social media refers to a collection of technological applications and platforms that were originally designed to support social interactions among individuals. While some of them (e.g. virtual communities) have been available for quite some time, there has been a recent surge in development of such applications, which has prompted a need to create a summary term and to better understand their use. Enticed by the large numbers of prospective customers reachable through these media and encouraged by the technology developers who integrated advertising-based business models to attract funding, it did not take long for companies to discover the commercial potential of social media. The viral component of social media makes them especially attractive as messages can achieve enormous reach without big marketing investments. However, due to the infancy and ongoing development of most of these social media, companies have yet to determine how to best use social media for marketing purposes. It is therefore important to look at the fundamental principles of social media and related consumer behaviours, and to infer theoretical foundations in order to identify marketing opportunities and inform marketing practice.

Interactive media, i.e. computer-based media that are able to respond to individual consumer inputs with specific content, offer unique possibilities for marketers to promote products and services but also require adjustments of marketing strategies (Schlosser & Kanfer, 2000). Interactive media call for interactive marketing, which is essentially built on information *from* the customer, not just *about* the customer (Day, 1998). Parsons, Zeisser and Waitman (1998) stress that successful interactive marketing includes 1) attracting users; 2) engaging users' interest and participation; 3) retaining users on sites; 4) learning about user preferences; and, 5) relating back to users in the form of customized interactions. Gretzel, Yuan and Fesenmaier (2000) already described the essential outcomes of such marketing approaches in the early days of online tourism marketing as deeper relationships and greater customization. Both are essential for survival in the increasingly competitive tourism domain.

Social media marketing builds on these assumptions of interactive marketing, but the interactive media it takes advantage of are fundamentally different from the websites available when the first interactive marketing strategies were developed. Social media marketing is essentially interactive marketing "on steroids", with a much greater focus on relationships and a more active role of consumers in creating and distributing marketing messages than in traditional forms of marketing. It is fuelled by an increasing number of interactive media that support social interactions such as co-creation and content sharing and a growing number of users worldwide. For example, eMarketer (2012) predicts that in 2012 about one in every five people worldwide will use social networking sites, with the largest populations of users residing in China and the United States and growth rates being the highest in India and Indonesia. Given this massive adoption of social media around the globe, social media marketing will soon become a standard way for marketers to interact with consumers. This means that a fundamental shift in communication approaches across all media and in the structure of company-customer relationships is to be expected. To anticipate this change, it is important to understand the basic social media marketing principles.

This chapter will give a basic overview of social marketing principles and strategies, discussing its premises and promises specifically in the context of tourism, where the nature of

the product and the context of interactions create unique opportunities but also lead to enormous challenges for social media marketers.

## SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING DEFINED

Social media marketing discourse is full of acronyms that are often used interchangeably but sometimes refer to slightly different things or perspectives. Also, while in-depth knowledge of the technology that drives social media marketing is not necessary, it is important to recognize the technological basis of these marketing initiatives and how the marketing approaches are intertwined with the developments and resulting cultures of the Internet and its specific applications. This section of the chapter provides definitions and presents fundamental assumptions that shape social media marketing philosophies.

### *Web 2.0, the Social Web, Social media, CGM, and UGC*

Web 2.0 refers to Internet technology and applications that allow users to be actively engaged in creating and distributing Web content (Gillin, 2007). While the Internet and the Web have always emphasized content creation and sharing, Web 2.0 technologies (e.g. XML, Ajax, API, RSS, mash-ups, etc.) make it a lot easier for data to be exchanged. Contents are much more moveable and interactions more visible, giving rise to what is often referred to as the Writable or Social Web (Gillin, 2009). As such, the term Social Web describes the totality of the phenomenon, including technologies, contents and connections. Safko and Brake (2009:6) describe the Social Web as “activities, practices, and behaviours among communities of people who gather online to share information, knowledge, and opinions”. The notion of the Social Web therefore emphasizes aspects of the Web that make it a networked conversation space in which social dynamics play an important role.

While Web 2.0 refers to the technological base including programming languages and protocols that support the participatory nature of the Web, social media represent the platforms and channels through which content is created and shared. Thus, social media are Web-based applications built on the philosophical and technical foundations of the Web 2.0 that make it possible to create and easily transmit content (Safko & Brake, 2009; Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010). The text, pictures, videos, audio files, etc. created and shared through social media are called user-generated contents (UGC) (Gillin, 2007) or consumer-generated media (CGM). The latter term is somewhat problematic in that it does not recognize the growing amount of content generated by corporate users. Both terms however stress that, in contrast to websites based on Web 1.0 technologies, social media contain contents produced by individuals other than the immediate owner/publisher of the site. Social media are all about people sharing opinions, experiences, expertise, interesting links, etc. (Gillin, 2009).

It is important to recognize that the term social media encompasses a large array of specific types of media such as blogs, message boards, review sites, social networking sites, etc. Safko and Brake (2009) describe the phenomenon as a social media eco-system. This recognizes that social media do not represent a uniform species of technology applications but rather a multitude of channels and platforms that are interlinked and perform different functions. According to Constantinides and Fountain (2008), there are five main categories of social media, which include 1) blogs; 2) social networks; 3) content communities; 4) forums/bulletin boards; and, 5) content aggregators. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) classified social media into six types based on the degree of social presence/media richness and the degree of self presentation/disclosure. Their classification of social media includes blogs/microblogs (e.g. Twitter), social networking sites (e.g. Facebook), virtual social worlds (e.g. Second Life),

collaborative projects (e.g. Wikipedia), content communities (e.g. YouTube) and virtual game worlds (e.g. World of Warcraft). The social media ecosystem is dynamic in that new social media types constantly emerge (e.g. Pinterest), some types become extinct (e.g. Friendster) and the prominence of a specific medium can change (e.g. MySpace evolving from a dominant social networking platform to a niche medium). Some of them even live in symbiosis, e.g. tweets can be displayed on Facebook pages.

The various social media types provide unique affordances in terms of the type of content that can be created and shared as well as the way of sharing. They have also developed their own conventions of what is appropriate and desirable. The different social media attract very different users (Gretzel et al., 2011) and are characterized by specific cultures. Moreover, they provide marketers with varying options in terms of presenting and promoting content, interacting and forming relationships with existing and potential customers, and obtaining market intelligence.

### *The Social Media Marketing Paradigm*

Social media marketing can be defined as using social media channels to promote a company and its products (Barefoot & Szabo, 2010). The main difference is that the audience of the marketing messages not only consumes but also actively creates marketing contents (Evans, 2008). Step 2 of the interactive marketing process (engaging users' interest and participation) (Parsons et al., 1998) is therefore critical in social media marketing campaigns. Engagement is indeed one of the buzzwords often used in social media marketing. Evans (2008) sees it as one of three pillars: engagement, action and loyalty. It assumes an active audience of prosumers (Toffler, 1980) who want to interact with marketers beyond the immediate sales transaction. It further acknowledges that loyalty in social media cannot be assumed, but must be actively assured (Kozinets, 1999). Social media marketing thus falls within the new marketing logic described by Vargo and Lusch (2004), which, instead of focusing on tangible resources, embedded value, and transactions, fully embraces intangible resources, co-creation of value, and relationships.

Social media marketing is essentially about building relationships (Barefoot & Szabo, 2010). In order to build those relationships, it needs to enable and shape conversations (Safko & Brake, 2009). Social media marketers are therefore conversation managers who develop methods to strategically influence conversations (Mangold & Faulds, 2009). Consequently, social media marketing is concerned with how conversations can be prompted, promoted and monetized (Safko & Brake, 2009). Consumers are active participants and equal partners in these conversations who co-create value together with marketers by exchanging resources and information (Vargo & Lusch, 2004). It is important to note that this means marketers cannot control these conversations but can only try to influence them. User-generated contents can either reinforce marketing efforts or beat marketers at their own games (Evans, 2008). It also implies that marketers need to obtain an intricate understanding of how meaning creation happens in a particular social media type and what use conventions have emerged so that they can manage conversations in a way that is appreciated rather than seen as intrusive by the consumers.

Social media marketing is based on traditional marketing but adopts a fundamentally different philosophy in terms of the way interactions with potential and actual customers are structured. Birch (2011) describes social media marketing as being focused on 4 R's rather than the traditional 4 P's (Table 1). Similarly, Gunelius (2011) calls for well-planned, active, and continuous engagement with influential consumers. This requires intricate knowledge of the

social media types and their users, a long-haul commitment, and continuous engagement through interesting content.

**Table 1. Marketing Paradigm Shift (adapted from Birch, 2011)**

| <i>Classic Marketing</i>               | <i>21st Century Marketing</i>                      | <i>Social Media Marketing</i>                                                  |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Product<br>Price<br>Place<br>Promotion | Experience<br>Exchange<br>Everyplace<br>Evangelism | Relationship<br>Return on Engagement<br>Reach based on Relevance<br>Reputation |

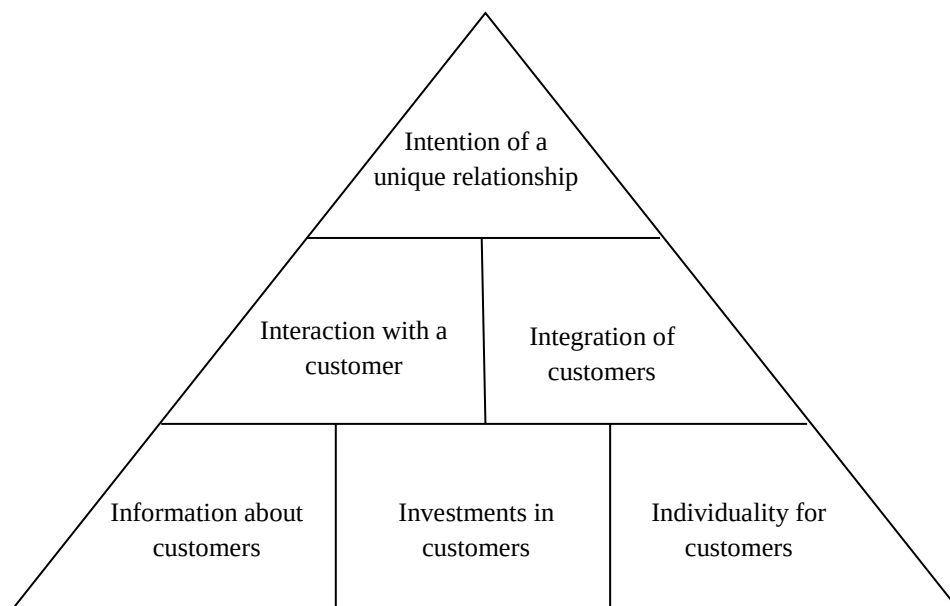
Reputation management is an important aspect of social media marketing as much of the consumer-generated content consists of opinions/reviews. Given the focus on conversations and reputation, social media marketing has a lot of similarities with public relations. However, it would be naive to narrow it down to just that. As illustrated by Yoo and Gretzel (2010), social media marketing functions span across all elements of marketing (Table 2). Therefore, social media marketing efforts should be seen as all-encompassing and as complementary extensions of other marketing efforts instead of a replacement (Evans, 2008). It is important to note the much greater emphasis on research. This is the case not only because of the participatory culture and high trackability of interactions on social media but also the greater need to inform targeting to cut through the clutter and encourage viral spread.

**Table 2. Social Media Marketing Functions (adapted from Yoo & Gretzel, 2010)**

| <b>Marketing Functions</b> | <b>Traditional Marketing</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Social Media Marketing</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Customer Relations         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- One-way communication</li> <li>- Offline customer service center</li> <li>- Limited customer data</li> <li>- B2C communication</li> <li>- Prescribed solutions; scripted responses</li> <li>- Delayed response</li> <li>- One-off interaction</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Interaction</li> <li>- Online customer service</li> <li>- Customer identification with data mining</li> <li>- Virtual customer communities</li> <li>- Crowd sourcing</li> <li>- Real-time communication</li> <li>- Relationship</li> </ul> |
| Product                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Limited product information</li> <li>- Mass products for mainstream markets</li> <li>- Company-created products</li> </ul>                                                                                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Value added info. on products: Pictures, video, catalog, consumer reviews etc.</li> <li>- Product customization</li> <li>- Co-creation with consumers</li> <li>- Digital/virtual product</li> </ul>                                        |
| Price                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- One-price pricing</li> <li>- Limited payment options</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Flexible pricing (Price transparency)</li> <li>- Online payment</li> <li>- Social buying</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                        |
| Promotion                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Offline promotions</li> <li>- One promotion message</li> <li>- Partnerships with traditional partners</li> <li>- Targeting customers</li> <li>- Mediated through mass media</li> </ul>                                                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Online promotions</li> <li>- Customized promotion messages</li> <li>- Non-traditional partnerships</li> <li>- Customer participation</li> <li>- Viral spread facilitated by Web 2.0 tools</li> </ul>                                       |
| Place                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Intermediaries</li> <li>- Required time to process order/booking</li> <li>- Offline distribution of products</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Dis-/ Re-intermediation</li> <li>- Real-time ordering and processing</li> <li>- Online distribution of products</li> </ul>                                                                                                                 |
| Research                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Delayed results</li> <li>- Push</li> <li>- Encouraged through incentives</li> <li>- No follow-up</li> <li>- Mediated</li> <li>- Sporadic</li> <li>- Costly</li> </ul>                                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Real-time info through RSS or email alerts</li> <li>- Pull</li> <li>- Based on altruistic motivations</li> <li>- Immediate reaction</li> <li>- Unmediated</li> <li>- Continuous</li> </ul>                                                 |

|                         |                                                             |                                                         |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
|                         | - Response limited to numbers and text                      | - Free data<br>- Multiple formats                       |
| Performance Measurement | - Leads<br>- Discrete times<br>- Hard sales/visitor numbers | - Conversations<br>- Continuous<br>- Consumer sentiment |

Both Table 1 and Table 2 clearly illustrate the focus on customer relationships. Diller (2000) identifies the building blocks of relationship marketing as encompassing “6 i’s” (Figure 1): 1) information about customers; 2) investments in customers; 3) individuality for customers; 4) interaction with customers; 5) integration of customers; and, 6) intention of a unique relationship. These principles still hold true for social media marketing but the way they are defined and implemented is fundamentally different. Information about customers is a fundamental component but now not only includes basic demographic and transactional data but a massive amount of opinions and social data that is readily available to companies. Marketers still need to decide in which customers to invest but customer value needs to be redefined and customer expectations of what an “investment” in them looks like have changed. Also, the enormous amounts of data available allow for different segmentation approaches and the nature of social media allows for extensive behavioural targeting not possible before. Individuality through personalization creating an aura of exclusivity is essential for traditional relationship marketing while in a social media context customers are more concerned with relevance and social sharing of offers. Interaction with customers and their integration into value-creation processes have reached new levels in social media marketing with interaction being continuous and customers being more than willing to provide inputs in a variety of ways (Sigala, 2012). Both build fundamentally on the data, segmenting, targeting and personalizing that represent the base of the relationship marketing pyramid. Also, in addition to customer-company interactions, social media marketing is about stimulating and supporting customer-customer interactions, a tactic often referred to as tribal marketing (Pace, Fratocchi & Cocciola, 2007). There is still an intention to build a lasting relationship but companies cannot expect that this means customers will not form similar relationships with competitors. Also, these relationships are now visible to other customers and competitors (e.g. customers “liking” of a company is visible on their Facebook timeline).



**Figure 1: Relationship Marketing Pyramid (adapted from Diller 2000)**

In order to design and implement successful social media marketing campaigns, it is essential to understand the culture on which social media-based interactions are formed. The Social Web is all about democracy, community, collaboration, authenticity and transparency (Barefoot & Szabo, 2010). Social media contents contribute to informed consumption choices by aggregating and making available the collective experience and resultant conversations of consumers (Evans, 2008). Social media of the pre-marketing days were platforms where consumers turned to each other for unbiased information, avoiding ads and sales pitches. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) stress the importance of acknowledging that social media marketing is fundamentally about participation, sharing, and collaboration rather than straightforward advertising and selling. This puts marketers into an unfamiliar and somewhat awkward situation and has prompted some to pose as consumers in a desperate attempt to fit in with the rest of the social media users and their conversations. Many of these efforts backfired as they violate the transparency principle. Marketers need to be genuine partners in the social media conversations in order to be respected and listened to.

Trust is essential to any form of conversation on the Social Web (Evans, 2008), and such trust needs to be earned. While consumer-based word-of-mouth is typically seen as trustworthy, marketers have to work hard in order to establish credibility in the social media space. This can only be done through open and authentic communication that aims at generating genuine connections. Meerman Scott (2007) summarizes the social media marketing paradigm as follows:

- Authenticity instead of spin
- Participation instead of propaganda
- Close the sale, continue the conversation.

Thus, it becomes clear that social media marketing is still very much based on basic marketing principles aiming at profit maximization, but that the focus and the tools are fundamentally different.

## SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING STRATEGIES

The paradigm shift in underlying assumptions implies a need for innovative strategies to achieve marketing success in the new conversation space. Strategic marketing questions to be asked are how social media can be used to create additional business value and how they can help in the realms of customer acquisition and retention (Constantinides & Fountain, 2008). Unfortunately, there is not much academic literature available that has specifically looked at marketing strategy in the context of social media. This section of the chapter therefore summarizes strategy insights mostly derived from social media marketing practice.

One fundamental strategic decision to make relates to channel presence. Hamill, Stevenson and Attard (2012) distinguish between “high” (present in two-thirds or more of the available channels), “medium” (present in half to two-thirds), and “low” (presence in less than half). Many of the channels can now be linked (e.g. Twitter updates and Pinterest posts appear on Facebook, and videos posted on YouTube can be inserted into other social media postings), allowing for important synergies. The channel presence strategy decision is a function of the target markets and their specific preferences for certain social media. It is important to stress that the social media landscape is dynamic and that the channel presence needs to be continuously adjusted.

The other element is the engagement profile. It describes the depth and level of engagement within a specific social medium (Hamill et al., 2012). Indeed, Hamill et al. (2012) convincingly argue that mere presence is not enough for achieving social media success. Rather it requires interesting conversations to be held with the right audience. Taking together, channel presence and engagement profile lead to four generic types of social media strategy (Elowitz & Li, 2009): 1. Mavens (high level of engagement across a range of social media); 2. Butterflies (use of a large number of social media but only low to medium engagement); 3. Selectives (high engagement in a small number of media); and, 4. Wallflowers (small number of channels and only low to medium engagement).

Overall, social media marketing strategy has to tackle two big issues: 1) which social media among the plethora of available types to select; and, 2) how to communicate within a specific medium. The diversity of social media makes it impossible to be present in all and requires selection based on relevance for specific marketing goals (Gunelius, 2011). Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) also stress the importance of choosing social media outlets carefully and taking advantage of already existing applications instead of re-inventing the wheel. They also strongly argue for ensuring activity alignment across social media, as well as making certain that employees stand fully behind the company's social media engagement. This suggests that internal marketing takes on a significant role in the context of social media marketing.

It is important to note that social media marketing and search engine marketing are closely intertwined strategies. Social media provide increased online visibility (Barefoot & Szabo, 2010). The structure of social media makes them attractive for search engine spiders, increasing the likelihood of social media to be frequently indexed and to appear on top of search listings (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Providing interesting contents on a website or blog encourages users to link to the content through their social media platforms, which increases the incoming links for the page on which the content resides. On the other hand, marketers have to assure that their social media content can be found. For messages to effectively diffuse a social network, they have to reach central (influential) nodes (Pan & Crotts, 2012). This, in turn, requires an understanding of who the influencers are in a social network and how they can be best reached using social media channels.

Social media marketing strategies need to be culturally sensitive. First, the availability, penetration, and popularity of certain social media types differ significantly across countries (Gretzel, Kang & Lee, 2008). Second, the very same social media are used differently by different cultures. For instance, Lee, Yoo and Gretzel (2009) found significant differences in the way US and Korean travellers use blogs to communicate their tourism experiences, with US blogs being more focused on recording and sharing one's personal experience while Korean bloggers focus on giving recommendations to influence the experiences of others. Third, specific social media platforms emphasize specific modes of communication, including recreational, informational, transformational, and relational modes (Kozinets, 1999). This leads to the creation of social media type-specific interaction cultures. Gunelius (2011) points out that social media marketing requires learning how consumers engage in a specific social media type and what value they want to derive from their engagement.

Whatever the specific strategy is, its execution needs to reflect what the company stands for. Given the value placed on trust and authenticity by most social media users, approaches have to be genuine and backed by the necessary resources. Hiring a PR firm or advertising agency to implement the overall strategy appears to be inherently counter-productive. However, certain aspects of social media marketing might have to be outsourced given the resource constraints



of smaller organizations and the intense and continuous level of engagement required by some social media initiatives.

## MEASURING SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING OUTCOMES

Relevance can only be assured if social media are continuously monitored and effects of marketing campaigns are effectively tracked. Fortunately, interactions in the social media space leave digital traces that can be tracked and measured. The issue is what should be tracked and how it can be translated into measures that can directly inform strategic marketing decisions. This section offers a brief overview of social media monitoring as a way to inform social media marketing strategies.

Based on the definition of social media as conversation spaces, monitoring involves trying to understand who is talking to whom and what they are saying (Evans, 2008). One of the problems to consider when monitoring social media-based conversations is that there are different levels of user engagement (Tedjamulia, Olsen, Dean & Albrecht, 2005). The majority of users are lurkers and only a small percentage of users are active content creators (Yoo & Gretzel, 2011; Gillin, 2009). These content creators have specific demographic characteristics and personalities and might not be representative of the company's typical target market. Another challenge lies in most content posted being positive (Gillin, 2009; De Ascaniis & Gretzel, 2012). Overall ratings of experiences such in the case of travel reviews, for example, do often not reflect the actual content of the review (Jiang, Gretzel & Law, 2010). This means that superficial measures can be very misleading and general brand sentiment might not be a very insightful measure. It is very important to include not only the conversations these consumers have with the marketers but also those they have among themselves. This requires knowing where such conversations take place.

The currency of social media marketing is influence. This means that the effectiveness of social media marketing campaigns should be measured in terms of influence. This is not only a question of what kind of influence is exercised but also on whom. The goal is to reach those who will likely help spread the message. Influencers in the social media space are a new breed of opinion leaders and should not be confused with traditional influencers (e.g. celebrities, etc.). Influencers can be described based on their level and type of engagement with the brand as well as their desire and ability to influence others (Gillin, 2009). Influencers play a critical role in shaping conversations. There are increasing efforts in the social media space to identify those with greater influence than others. Klout (<http://klout.com/home>) is an example of such an initiative.

Success in social media marketing is not about return on investment but rather return on engagement (Frick, 2010). Harden and Heyman (2009) describe the "mathematics of engagement" as requiring a focus on click depth rather than just clicks, loyalty (number of visits), recency (return visits within a certain time frame), visit duration, interactivity (consumer actions such as comments, retweets, etc.), and commitment (e.g. subscription). These outputs have to be related to the engagement inputs on the marketer side, e.g. the number of posts, types of contents posted, frequency of posts, etc.

The relationship focus of social media marketing implies that its value is the network, i.e. the connections established with consumers and other stakeholders (Gillin, 2009). However, not all connections are equal. Thousands of "likes" on Facebook and "followers" on Twitter are only of value if they represent genuine connections. While research exists on motivations of consumers to contribute contents in virtual communities (Yoo & Gretzel, 2009), very little

information exists on why consumers would want to connect with companies. Gretzel (2010) found that most consumers define their relationships with companies on Facebook as functional and benefit-based rather than emotional. Understanding what drives consumers to connect with marketers is critical in being able to provide value.

The strategic need for social media monitoring has led to the emergence of social media monitoring tools, which are applications that facilitate monitoring across multiple social media channels by indexing relevant information, providing mechanisms for marketers to search the information (e.g. by keyword, date, etc.), and allowing for further analysis and data visualisation (Stevenson & Hamill, 2012). Stevenson and Hamill (2012) have identified over 200 of such tools currently available. Their main uses lie in supporting active listening to consumer-driven conversations and measuring the effectiveness of social media marketing campaigns. Social media monitoring tools are supported by general Web analytics tool.

In summary, new marketing assumptions need new ways to measure performance. The above suggests that social media monitoring is an emerging field that has yet to establish sound measures and measurement approaches but at the same time relies heavily on the ability to determine success beyond established marketing effectiveness measures such as impressions and conversion. Thus, it can be assumed that social media monitoring will continue to receive increased attention from researchers and practitioners.

## CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR SOCIAL MEDIA MARKETING IN TOURISM

Conversations are fundamental elements of tourism information search and decision-making. The sharing of experiences through personal narratives, pictures, etc. is also an integral part of tourism experiences (Gretzel et al., 2011). The personal experience accounts of others serve as input for those planning vacations or as inspiration for the future. Therefore, it is not surprising that social media have become heavily used by travellers to document and communicate their experiences and to inform their decisions (Yoo & Gretzel, 2008; Fotis, Buhalis & Rossides, 2012). Tourism content is inherently experiential and very engaging and, therefore, a seemingly natural fit for social media. There is also often a strong feeling of solidarity among fellow travellers and an acknowledgement that experiential tourism information should be shared with others to help improve their tourism experiences and promote those providers that offer exceptional service. Some of the early virtual communities were actually tourism-related (e.g. the Lonelyplanet thorn tree forum) and simply mimicked the sharing behaviours that were already occurring through other media (e.g. comments left on bulletin boards in hostels). This can make one assume that tourism is a perfect match for social media marketing endeavours. However, marketers have to recognize that many of the platforms emerged for the very purpose of avoiding conversations with marketers and a clear distrust in information coming from travel companies. Couchsurfing.com is the ultimate negation of the commercial travel industry, trying to cut companies completely out of the picture. On the other hand, tourism products are often seen as status symbols and important elements of identity construction (Lee et al., 2009). Associating with a travel company or destination through social media can be an important part of establishing a social traveller identity. Yet, travellers will probably be very careful in choosing companies and destinations they want to openly associate with.

Another aspect of tourism that needs to be recognized is variety seeking and low purchase incidences. The main question is whether tourists want to commit to long-term relationships with travel companies or destinations if they really only consume their products once in a while or actually only once in a lifetime. While a deep relationship might be useful in the planning

phases, during the trip and immediately after a vacation, the value of a relationship beyond that has to be questioned. While there is a lot of focus on the “rules of engagement” in social media, there is clearly also a need to discuss “rules of disengagement”, especially in tourism. The need for such disengagement from a consumer perspective will of course largely depend on the type of social medium used and the kinds of interactions it fosters, with some media being more “pushy” than others. The question is whether content continuously pushed toward users who no longer have an immediate interest in the company can actually lead to negative effects. Social media marketers in tourism need to carefully think about opportunities to engage with users who might no longer have a desire to travel to a specific destination or use specific services. Social media marketing in tourism thus requires a very holistic view of the customer lifecycle.

Much has been said about different social media types requiring different strategic approaches. Given the complexity and diversity of players in the tourism industry, one has to also consider that strategies have to be adjusted based on the specific type of provider. Empirical research conducted by Gretzel and colleagues (Gretzel, 2010; Gretzel & Fesenmaier, 2012) indicates that relationships formed with destinations on Facebook are fundamentally different from those formed with travel companies such as hotels, airlines and restaurants. While relationships with travel companies are formed to obtain exclusive deals, relationships with destinations are more focused on information and expressing emotional attachment. Such differences have to be acknowledged and taken into account when deciding on strategies.

There are many small tourism providers and destination marketing organizations (DMOs) who do not have the organizational capacities to engage in labour-intensive social media campaigns. While social media provide immense opportunities to level the playing field by offering marketing opportunities with low entry costs and potentially immense reach, there are barriers to adoption based on lack of knowledge and lack of human resources. Continuous conversations require someone to actually engage with potential and actual consumers. Hamill et al. (2012) applied the Elowitz and Li typology presented above to national DMOs in Europe and found that only one DMO was actually a maven, engaging deeply across a wide range of social media. Shao, Davila Rodriguez and Gretzel (2012) illustrate how some DMOs have taken advantage of social media (e.g. through hosting polls on Facebook that introduce potential travellers to the various attractions at a destination) and have experimented with different approaches (e.g. linking the destination’s YouTube channel to Google Maps and encourage sharing through a variety of social media platforms). However, the research also recognizes that in general, social media are not used to their full potential in the destination marketing realm.

## CONCLUSION

Social media marketing requires understanding the social dynamics of the Web as a vast networked space and further demands adjustments of marketing strategies to embrace the technological capabilities as well as the interaction cultures that have emerged in various social media types. Social media marketing campaigns are often perceived as cheap and therefore not carefully executed. The hidden costs lie in having to engage with consumers in much deeper, more authentic, more personal, and continuous manners than through traditional media. Consumer expectations are high in the social media space and negative word can spread fast. Deciding on where to establish a presence and how to enable and shape conversations are important strategic decisions. Social media marketing can also not happen in a vacuum but, rather, needs to complement the overall marketing mix strategies. For tourism marketers, social media open up a new world of possibilities to form meaningful connections with actual and

potential customers. However, social media engagement has to be carefully designed and continuously managed in order to be successful. This requires not only commitment of resources but often also a complete change in organizational culture, especially with respect to how the tourism organization manages customer relationships.

Social media marketing is a dynamic field with new technologies and new advertising models constantly emerging. This means that the social media landscape keeps changing and that social media marketing strategies have to be continuously adjusted to new and often fleeting realities. This makes it incredibly difficult to prescribe rules on how success can and should be achieved. The dynamic nature also stresses the need for research in this area and strong theoretical bases so that new phenomena can be described comprehensively, explained in detail, and maybe even anticipated. While general use of social media by travellers and motivations to create contents are receiving growing attention by researchers (Yoo & Gretzel, 2012; Cox et al., 2009), very little is currently known about how travellers perceive and react to specific marketing tactics implemented online and how they would prefer to relate and engage with travel companies and destinations through social media. Also, while there are considerable research efforts in the sentiment analysis space, these are often driven by computer scientists who have very little understanding of the intricate nature of tourism. Further, the theory-practice gap is especially large in social media marketing in tourism as many of the tourism businesses have yet to make the shift towards the data-driven approaches that form the basis of successful social media marketing. Therefore, there is a great need to build theory in this area and also to develop the appropriate methodologies that will allow for obtaining the insights needed from a theoretical as well as marketing practice point of view.

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